This is saying that our image will be based off the ruby:2.6 image, which, as you've probably guessed, has Ruby 2.6 preinstalled. We've chosen to start from this image because having Ruby installed is our biggest requirement, so this image gets us most of the way there.

Right at the Top: Base Images



There are several special images with no parent image—known as a *base image*—that ultimately all images depend on. They contain the minimal user filesystem for an operating system.

If you want to build your own stripped-down image, you could build your image FROM scratch (reads well, doesn't it?) where scratch is a minimal base image.

It's even possible to create your own base images,[1] although this is an advanced topic. We're not going to cover it since chances are you'll never need to do it.

The next two lines of our Dockerfile are RUN instructions, which tell Docker to execute a command:

```
RUN apt-get update -yqq
RUN apt-get install -yqq --no-install-recommends nodejs
```

Here, we tell Docker to run apt-get update -yqq, followed by apt-get install -yqq --no-install-recommends nodejs—but what do these two commands achieve for us?

As you may already know, apt-get is a command used to install software on Debian (and some other) Linux distributions.[2] We're using it in our Dockerfile because the official Ruby image that our image builds on top of is based on Debian—specifically, a version called Stretch.[3]

The apt-get update command tells the package manager to download the latest package information. Many Dockerfiles will have a similar line, because without it, apt has no package information at all, and therefore won't be able to install anything. The -yqq option is a combination of the -y option, which says to answer "yes" to any prompts, and the -qq option, which enables "quiet" mode to reduce the printed output.

Next, the apt-get install command installs Node.js, a prerequisite for running Rails. The --no-install-recommends says not to install other recommended but

1. docs.docker.com/engine/userguide/eng-image/baseimages/
2. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Advanced_Packaging_Tool
3. https://github.com/docker-library/ruby/blob/a04dd5259eaef8d682dae2bb709f03219a6e5905/2.5/stretch/Dockerfile#L1